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The last paradise for creative workers? The case of Shueisha and Weekly Shōnen Jump

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ABSTRACT

The Weekly Shōnen Jump, published by Shueisha, is widely seen as the most important publication in global manga culture and home to some of the world's most iconic media franchises, including Dragon Ball, and yet remains largely understudied. This article interrogates how Shōnen Jump's success, steered by editors who are often deemed 'uncreative' within Japan's inflexible employment framework, challenges the Western ideal of creativity that is associated with autonomy and flexibility. The inquiry is conducted through two primary processes: firstly, the recruitment of editors – considered as creative managers – through 'Shukatsu,' a Japanese system that predominantly favors elite university graduates, who often lack a passion for manga or relevant education and work experience; and secondly, the dynamics of their collaborative relationships with manga artists. Highlighting Shueisha's exceptional job security and stability, akin to a 'last paradise' for a select few creative professionals, this examination challenges the homogenized Western narrative of creative labor, as a class characterized by precarity and challenges the conventional perception of creativity itself.

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Introduction: powerful creative industries and weak interest in creativity

As the world's third-largest economy, Japan has built a formidable reputation as a major force in global cultural production. Japanese video games, anime, manga, fashion, films, architecture, literature, contemporary arts, and design have left a distinctive mark on global popular culture. In the 2021 'The 25 Highest-Grossing Media Franchises of All Time' (Hallman 2021), Japan's Pokémon topped the rankings at \$92 billion, followed by Hello Kitty at \$80 billion, comfortably ahead of Winnie the Pooh (\$75 billion), Micky Mouse (\$70 billion), and Star Wars (\$65 billion). In all, media franchises originating in Japan accounted for 10 of the top 25, second only to the US with 13. Of these Dragon Ball (\$24 billion), Fist of the North Star (\$21 billion), One Piece (\$21 billion), and Yu-Gi-Oh (\$19 billion) all originated as manga series in Weekly Shōnen Jump (*WJ* hereafter),¹ published by Shueisha Inc., one of the most important, yet least studied, media companies in the world.

Despite the global success of Japanese popular culture, there's a muted interest in the concepts of creativity or creative industries in Japan. For instance, the Japanese term for 'creative industries,' *sōzō sangyō*, is seldom employed beyond a select group of bureaucrats and scholars (Oyama 2015). This poses a contradiction: while Japan's creative sectors enjoy global prominence, many insiders and academics seem indifferent to the wider discourse on creativity. No company exemplifies this paradox more vividly than Shueisha, which produces

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highly successful global media franchises but receives almost no attention from scholars, particularly within the context of creativity. Moreover, manga is often termed the ‘mother content’ (Tokiwa-so Project 2011), which needs a relatively small investment to produce (1101.com 2023) but gives rise to anime, films, and video games that evolve into extensive media franchises, underlining the significance of scholarly inquiry.

This article explores a paradox at the heart of *WJ* global success. *WJ*’s significant global achievements are led by a group of editors, who are hired through Japan’s standardized graduate recruitment system that often overlook prior work experience or relevant qualifications or passion and work within a conventional Japanese employment system. This system is typified by lifetime employment, seniority-based salary and promotion, and company loyalty, which may not appear immediately conducive to producing highly creative outputs. This success stands in contrast to the neoliberal values of ‘self-enterprise,’ ‘autonomy,’ and freedom prevalent in Western creative industries discourse. The exceptional job security at Shueisha sharply contrasts with Western standards, it can practically be seen as the last paradise of creative workers, insulated from the typical precariousness.

This article poses this question: How does *WJ*’s success, orchestrated by editors selected through Japan’s rigid employment systems and sustained by a culture of job security and loyalty, challenge the Western conception of creativity linked to autonomy, self-enterprise, and precariousness in creative work? The articles address this question on two main processes: the recruitment of editors – considered as creative managers – via ‘shukatsu,’ a Japanese system that favors elite university graduates, often without a passion for manga or related experience, and the dynamics of their collaborative relationships with manga artists (mangaka). Such examination challenges the homogenized Western narrative of creative labor, which frequently depicts creative workers uniformly as a class marked by precarity.

Literature review: creative managers, recruitment, and uncreativity

In this article, I use the term creative workers to refer to individuals involved in the production of symbolic goods in the creative and cultural industries (Banks 2007). Arguing against the utopian and romantic celebration of creative labour as autonomous, self-expressive, and fulfilling (e.g. Florida 2002; Howkins 2007; Landry 2000), creative labor research stresses that work in cultural and creative industries is characterized by high levels of insecurity, casualization, and reproduction of already-existing inequalities (Banks, Gill, and Taylor 2013; Brook, O’Brien, and Taylor 2020; Curtin and Sanson 2016; Hesmondhalgh and Baker 2011). Following the pioneering works of Ross (2009) and McRobbie (2002, 2016), this body of research shows how mostly young creative workers willingly subject themselves to seeming exploitation and precarity (Hesmondhalgh and Baker 2011, 6–7).

To unravel this paradox, substantial studies have explored how motivations and work ethics in creative fields are driven by factors like autonomy (Banks 2010), a passion for creativity (Kim 2013), or self-expression (Duffy 2017). These studies paint and critique an idealized image of a creative worker, where the pursuit of creativity is closely tied to flexibility, freedom, and even enduring ‘precarity’ in their professional lives. In this context, while aiming to critique the inequality and injustices faced by many creative workers, critical studies of creative labor often present a homogenous portrayal of creative work as inherently intertwined with precarity. This article offers a case study from Shueisha, where creativity is decoupled from precarity, with all its faults and a set of distinct problems, and thereby presents a more nuanced understanding of creative labor in a global landscape.

This section serves to: 1) Conceptualize Shueisha editors as creative managers; 2) Explore the recruitment contexts within Japanese media industries, along with a broader review of trends in recruitment literature in creative labour studies; 3) Examine key literature regarding the collaboration between creative managers and primary creative workers; 4) examines key literature in creative labor studies in Japan and East Asia.

Manga editors as creative managers

Critical creative labour studies recognize that there is a division of labor in creative industries. Hesmondhalgh and Baker (2011, 9–10) group creative workers into five categories: primary creative workers, such as manga authors; creative managers, such as magazine editors; administrators; executives; and unskilled labor. The contributions, prestige, security, and financial rewards differ among these groups. Creative managers often act as intermediaries between profit-focused owners and executives, and creative personnel, seeking success and reputation through innovative works (Hesmondhalgh 2019, 92).

Moreover, although they all form part of the creative production process, some groups, particularly primary creative workers, have received more scholarly attention than others, such as creative managers, which, as a group, have received relatively scarce attention.² Yet, existing research (e.g. Havens 2014; Lotz 2014) underscores the significant influence of creative managers in cultural production. Havens observes that their presumptions about what is commercially viable, referred to as ‘industry lore’ significantly shape the range of texts that are perceived as likely to succeed (Havens 2014, 31).

In Western literature on creative labor, distinction between creative managers and primary creative workers in terms of job security and worsening working conditions are often overlooked (e.g. Boston and Duffy 2016). Both are frequently seen as equally vulnerable to precarity – a perspective in sharp contrast to the practices at Shueisha. In this article, I will frame manga editors as creative managers who belong to a higher and more secure layer in the production of manga compared to mangaka, who are primary creative workers and face the same precarious conditions similar to those depicted in much of the Western literature. Viewed in this light, further qualification is needed. This ‘paradise’ is carefully constructed and maintained for creative managers, to the exclusion of mangaka, who are primary creative workers. Understanding this hierarchy is crucial, and an examination of the recruitment system that influences the interplay between these two categories of workers, editors and mangaka, will be pivotal.

Recruitment dynamics in the Japanese masukomi industry

The Masukomi industry, Japan’s cornerstone in cultural and creative industries like broadcasting, publishing, newspapers, and advertising, has exhibited remarkable stability and insularity. This resilience has led to a sustained dominance by established entities such as Kodansha (established in 1909), Shogakukan (established in 1922), and Shueisha (established in 1926), fending off competition from the Western companies (Oyama 2015). These companies’ recruitment practices, deeply rooted in a ‘membership-type’ employment system where companies treat employees as lifelong members of the company, provide lifetime employment, seniority-based promotions, age-based salary and bonuses, and a suite of benefits that often exceed those of large banks and manufacturing giants like Toyota and Sony (Seike 2022). Due to globalization, some Japanese companies are shifting toward ‘job-type employment’ where focus is on the specific role or job at hand, emphasizing skills and individual performance with less emphasis on job security. Nevertheless, this transition is slow and has ‘not replaced but been layered upon the existing practices’ (Kambayashi 2015; Rear 2022, 509). Many influential conservative politicians have placed their offspring in these companies through nepotism, which further underscores the stability and conservatism inherent in these sectors.³ To gain membership into this elite class of creative managers involves navigating the formal and organized Shukatsu process – a nationwide recruitment method unlike any other globally, which will be explained in detail later.

In contrast, Western creative industries often embrace a more fluid, ‘job-type’ employment model. Recruitment therein typically targets only professionals with relevant experience, who are also more likely to have relevant education compared to their Japanese counterparts. However, there is a dearth of literature on the recruitment of creative managers specifically. Existing studies highlight

how creative workers, both primary and managerial, are hired through internships and other types of unpaid jobs (Figiel 2013; Hope and Figiel 2012), or hiring through personal networks (Eigler and Azarpour 2020; Gandini 2016; Taylor and Luckman 2020). Such literature empathize how these practices often exclude those who are socio-culturally or geographically disadvantaged or lack financial means (Perlin 2012), leading to limited workforce diversity (Gill 2014; Gruglis and Stoyanova 2009). While the recruitment and training of rare and unique creative talents, such as the hiring of clowns at Cirque du Soleil, have been studied (2016 quoted in Bérubé and Demers 2019, 4), the hiring of creative managers is less examined. A prevailing assumption suggests that both creative and managerial roles face similar informal recruitment processes. The study by Ashton and Noonan (2013), and the special issue by Bridgstock et al. (2015) investigate the link between academia and cultural work, but the structured recruitment methods in major media companies like Shueisha remain largely uncharted, warranting further investigation.

The literature frequently underscores the precariousness of creative roles, highlighting a dichotomy between the pursuit of autonomy, creativity, and self-expression, and the stability of employment (Banks 2010; Duffy 2017; Kim 2013). These narratives often fail to acknowledge the existence of structured approaches to recruitment and career progression, particularly within companies like Shueisha in Japan. This gap in the literature justifies a focused case study on how the Japanese recruitment model, specifically for creative managers, compares with their Western counterparts. The upcoming case study aims to empirically explore Shueisha's distinct recruitment and employment practices, thus contributing to a broader understanding of the dynamics at play in the recruitment of creative managers within the unique Japanese context.

Uncreativity: collaboration between editors and mangaka

The second part of the case study examines the collaboration between creative managers and primary creative workers. The concept of 'uncreativity' proposed by Chris Bilton (2015) highlights a crucial counterbalance in the creative process, challenging the preeminence of novelty by emphasizing the refinement and valuation of existing ideas. He articulates 'uncreativity' as a force that provides stability, asserting it 'provid[es] a necessary ballast' against the relentless quest for innovation (2). In manga production, editors manifest 'uncreativity' by guiding creative flows towards 'closure and resolution' (12), ensuring that works are not only novel but also possess enduring value.

Bilton underscores that 'uncreativity' involves a methodical approach to development, characterized by self-doubt and criticism, serving as a check against 'change for change's sake' (11). This philosophy is further explored in the context of manga production at *WJ*, where editors critically assess and integrate new ideas within the publication's long and successful tradition. 'uncreativity' is thus positioned not as an attack on creativity, but as a necessary critique of 'creativity as "mere novelty"' (12), with skepticism and resistance to change being vital to the creative process of manga production.

The symbiotic relationship between manga editors and writers might showcase 'uncreativity' as a pivotal element that infuses creativity with depth, ensuring that manga not only captivates but also resonates with cultural expectations of readers aided by various mechanisms such as Readers' Polls. Bilton's insights into 'uncreativity' reveal the indispensable role of editors in the manga industry, whose evaluative input ensures that new series are more than just inventive – they are meaningful contributions to *WJ* and its long tradition of storytelling and visual aesthetics.

Transitioning from theory to practice, the subsequent case study on Shueisha aims to not just examine but also enrich Bilton's concept by revealing a complex layer in the relationship between the creative and the 'uncreative'. Unlike the dynamics seen in flatter organizational structures, such as those between advertising managers and creators (Bérubé and Demers 2019), the *WJ* case study will uncover the more nuanced and hierarchical interplay at Shueisha. Here, the distinction between creative managers and artists is not merely functional; it underscores the disparities in social status and job security that characterize the manga industry's intricate hierarchy.

Creative labor studies in East Asia

Finally, there exist studies on creative workers in China (Alacovska and Gill 2019; de Kloet, Lin, and Chow 2020; Lin 2019), South Korea (Kim 2019; Kim and Lee 2022), and Hong Kong (Tse 2022), but research on creative workers in Japan remains scarce. There have been only a limited number of studies examining the working environments of animators in Japan (Condry 2013; Matsunaga 2017, 2020; Mōri 2011); these works primarily apply the sociology of work perspective to discuss the work ethics governing freelance animators. None of these studies, however, situate their research within the contemporary discourse on creative labor. In her ethnographic research on Kodansha, a major publisher, a British Japanese studies scholar Sharon Kinsella (2000, 162–201) touches upon power relations between editors and manga authors, highlighting the gap in education levels between the two as a source of stratification. However, Kinsella's research is primarily situated within the field of Japanese studies and, despite its empirical insights, doesn't align closely with this project's focus on creative labor studies.

Scholars who are working on the topics of creative labor in Asia do not simply appropriate the theoretical concepts from the Western cases; rather, they attempt to carefully contextualize them, raising the question of how differences found among different contexts might then speak to theoretical debates on precarity in creative labor. This article aims to contribute to this body of literature by providing an original contribution to the study of Japan's prominent but under-researched media companies as well as, as I have argued earlier, insights into the studies of creative managers and recruitment within the broader creative industries.

Shueisha, the Weekly Shonen Jump, and the recruitment

Company profile

Shueisha is a comprehensive publishing company founded in 1926 that publishes a wide range of magazines, manga, picture books, light novels, educational books, reference books, novels, and other books. It had over 700 employees and recorded revenues of over 200 billion yen (US\$1.8 billion) in 2021, making it one of the three largest publishers in Japan and around fifteenth largest in the world, similar in size to Condé Nast. In 2018, Shueisha, Kodansha, and Shogakukan together had 2,400 employees and generated 471 billion yen in revenue, accounting for 4.5% of the publishing workforce but 37% of the publishing market (METI 2018).

The *WJ* was launched in 1968 to compete with Kodansha's Weekly Shōnen Magazine and Shogakukan's Weekly Shōnen Sunday, soon surpassing its rivals to become the best-selling manga magazine of all time. The manga series that run in the magazine targets young male readers and contain many action scenes and a fair amount of 'gags'. Famously, friendship, effort, and victory represent *WJ*'s guiding principles; these themes are found in one form or another in nearly all *WJ* manga. In 1994, the magazine's circulation reached 6.53 million copies a week, a world record for a manga publication. Circulation began to decline in the early 2000s and now hovers at around 1.8 million, although the growth of digital distribution gave Shueisha its best-ever financial year in 2021. Successful *WJ* manga series have been turned into anime, video games, toys, novels, live-action films, and theme parks with several of them turning to global media franchises.

The data sources used in this case study include Shueisha recruitment websites for the years 2018–2022; several recruitment guidebooks for university students; newspaper and magazine articles; published autobiographies and interviews of current and former Shueisha *WJ* editors; television documentaries about *WJ*; the LinkedIn profiles of current and former Shueisha employees; and interviews I conducted with former and active magazine editors at Shueisha. For additional background, I also interviewed two dozen university students in my seminar who are involved in job hunting in media industries, including at Shueisha. I collected tweets and other social media communications by job-hunting students from recruitment-related websites.

The recruitment process at Shueisha

It's a common and almost ideologically driven practice for creative workers to move, or at least aspire to move, from one employer to another in search of better opportunities and lifestyles (Chow 2017; Florida 2005). In stark contrast, Shueisha primarily recruits inexperienced university graduates who remain with the company until retirement. Each year, Shueisha launches a website tailored for students participating in *shūshoku katsudō* (job hunting activity), colloquially known as *shūkatsu*. *Shūkatsu* represents the coordinated recruitment of new university graduates at a national level, a process that is significantly more structured and formal than job recruitment methods seen elsewhere globally. This website offers valuable insights not only into working conditions, recruitment, and promotion policies but also into the qualities and self-perceptions deemed crucial and attractive in both successful applicants and Shueisha employees (Shueisha 2022a).

There are two paths to secure a 'regular' position at Shueisha: one is through regular recruitment via the *shūkatsu* process, and the other is mid-career recruitment for candidates outside the *shūkatsu* system. However, between 2018 and 2023, Shueisha didn't openly advertise mid-career roles. While they do hire mid-career professionals for specialized roles like rights management, these employees typically have fewer opportunities than 'regular' university hires, who are primarily recruited through *shūkatsu* and who form the core cadre of the company hierarchy at major Japanese firms like Shueisha. As a result, *shūkatsu*-based regular recruitment is essentially the primary, and possibly the exclusive, entry point to Shueisha. This approach sharply contrasts with Western hiring practices. For instance, major Western publishers like Conde Nast (2022) sort job listings by location, category, and level, typically seeking candidates with extensive, specific experience. Even intern applicants are usually pursuing a related degree.

In 2023, Shueisha reported a total of 764 employees, of which some were on limited-term contracts. Over the preceding five years, the company consistently recruited approximately 20 new employees annually, exclusively through regular recruitment, maintaining a balanced gender distribution. The selection process is fiercely competitive, with an estimated 200 applicants for each available position (Motoki 2017). According to the specifications on Shueisha's (2022a) recruitment portal, eligible applicants should be born post-2 April 1997, and be prospective graduates by March 2023 from a four-year academic institution, either in Japan or abroad. This stipulation implies that successful candidates, regardless of their academic major, will be 25 years or younger at the commencement of their employment, thereby potentially excluding individuals who have pursued prolonged overseas studies or possess relevant advanced degrees. Historically, Shueisha's recruitment has been heavily skewed towards elite academic institutions, predominantly the University of Tokyo and Waseda University. Only once in recent years has it hired a student from one of Japan's roughly two dozen non-elite universities, mostly art schools, that offer publishing or manga-related courses of study.⁴

Shueisha offers some of the highest salaries in Japan. Young employees, those in their 20s, can earn up to 10 million yen annually (approximately \$93,000 using a 10-year average exchange rate) – a benchmark beyond the reach of 95% of Japanese workers. The company provides an array of benefits, including paid maternity and paternity leaves, company-sponsored mortgages, and allowances for child education, among others. Unlike many other major Japanese corporations with multiple offices domestically and internationally, Shueisha's sole location is in Tokyo. This means employees don't face potential unwanted transfers. The combination of competitive pay, benefits, and job stability makes Shueisha a highly sought-after employer.

Another notable feature of Shueisha's hiring process is its approach to recruitment, termed '*ikkatsu saiō*' or non-job-specific hiring. The company's official website emphasizes that they do not recruit for designated roles like editing or sales. Instead, after a multifaceted training period – which includes lectures, on-site training across various departments, bookstore visits, excursions to printing companies, and team-building activities – new hires are placed in departments that match their demonstrated skills during a short training (Tsukuru 2021a, 2021b). This is common practice at

large Japanese companies, where hundreds of fresh graduates are hired in bulk and then assigned to a department after a short period of training, even if it frequently conflicts with the graduates' original aspirations and training.

The interview process at Shueisha

In Shueisha's (2020) shūkatsu process, aimed at students graduating in March 2020, the application journey started in March 2019 with entry sheets, followed by an aptitude test, a first interview, a second interview coupled with a written exam, and three additional interviews, involving a range of interviewers from junior editors to executives (Tsukuru Publishing 2021a, 128–9).

The entry sheet required candidates to indicate their preferred department (typically editing or advertising), outline their ideal job, propose a business plan, and recount personal stories, including significant interpersonal relationships, life-changing events, and their responses to challenges. They were also queried on their favorite Shueisha products across various genres, such as magazines, books, comics, film, theater, television, live performances, and exhibitions.

By mid-March, selected students engaged in an initial online interview. Those who advanced underwent a second, in-person interview and a written exam, which spanned topics from American presidents and Japanese comedians to short essays on Dostoevsky, pop culture queries, and aspects of Japanese traditional arts, complex idiomatic expressions. The second interview was held in a spacious meeting room, where candidates were urged to forego the traditional, dark shūkatsu suits in favor of attire that would more accurately reflect their individuality. In this round, they articulated their publishing interests, brainstormed business initiatives for their chosen departments, critiqued Shueisha publications, and shared insights into their reading and viewing habits. They were also probed on how they would adapt if placed in a department, not of their choosing (Tsukuru Publishing 2021a, 112–3).

Applicants have stated that while rigorous, the preparatory process is manageable, informed by guidance from alumni, specialized shūkatsu prep schools, and specialized shūkatsu media. Notably, a candidate's ability to present engaging narratives, demonstrate quick thinking, and possess a broad cultural knowledge often outweighs the importance of formal education or extensive professional experience in the selection process.

Introducing first-year employees

Every year, Shueisha introduces its new recruits on its recruitment website in friendly and entertaining ways. In 2020, Ms. A, assigned to *Non-no*, a women's fashion magazine, held a degree in political economy but was passionate about good comedies and good-looking men (Shueisha 2019). She grew up reading manga, which unsurprisingly left her with limited fashion knowledge. She didn't dislike fashion but questioned her fit as a fashion magazine editor. Her introduction included a remarkable transformation, from a conventional candidate in a suit to a vibrant advocate for *Non-no*, sporting a multicolored dotted shirt, denim, and a pair of sneakers. The 2023 recruitment website introduced Mr. B, an intercollegiate soccer player who nearly turned pro (Shueisha 2022b). His dream job would have been the sports magazine *Sportiva*, but he was assigned to *WJ*. His boss praised his tireless work ethic and willingness to put in long hours, qualities often found in individuals with athletic backgrounds and valued by the *masukomi* industry befit for creative manager class.

A review of Shueisha's recruitment websites from 2018 to 2022 revealed a recurring theme – new employees frequently found themselves in roles divergent from their initial passions, interests, or formal education. These 'mismatches' were typical among freshly minted Japanese university graduates. Shueisha portrayed them as amusing episodes and real-life lessons, emphasizing that the 'passion for work' that might draw creative workers elsewhere was not always taken into

consideration within the company. Nevertheless, the prospect of undesired assignments did not dissuade top university graduates.

Significantly, the Shueisha website disclosed the results of a questionnaire survey of students who had received job offers to begin in April (Shueisha 2022b). When asked about other industries they had applied to, 50% mentioned newspapers, 20% advertising and television, and intriguingly, 30% applied to manufacturing companies, 20% trading companies, and 10% to banks or finance companies. Only 10% applied exclusively to publishers. On average, students applied to around 20 companies across various industries, with only two or three of them being publishers. This trend showed that only the three largest publishers in Japan could compete with the salary and benefits offered by major companies in other sectors. Notably, only 56.5% considered the publishing sector as their top choice before commencing their job search, and as many as 30% ranked it lower than their fourth choice. This means in theory, as many as 44% would have gone to Sony, Mitsui, or Dentsu rather than Shueisha had they received an offer. It was clear that for most surveyed, their interest in publishing was contingent on receiving a top-tier salary, and they seem to have no intention of settling for less to work within the publishing industry. In fact, the most well-known current editor of the online edition of *WJ* called *Jump+*, Lin Shihei, openly admitted to receiving multiple job offers from companies in manufacturing and insurance but chose Shueisha for its higher salary.

Shueisha's commitment to conventional recruitment presents a paradox in the creative industries. Despite global trends favoring self-enterprising and entrepreneurial spirits, Shueisha continues to try to secure Japan's top graduates with the promise of stability and competitive benefits, a strategy that defies the rising call for a more Western-style employment system even by the Japanese government as part of its drive to new capitalism (Kantei 2023). In this context, Shueisha's system, distinctively decoupling creativity from the precarity and emphasizing stability and loyalty, is designed to nurture and systematically develop creative talents over time. Contrasting with the fluid and individualistic nature of Western creative industries, this approach fosters a consistent cultivation of creativity, rooted in long-term professional growth and internal mentorship. This not only reflects cultural and systemic differences but also sets the stage for understanding the distinct collaborative dynamics between editors and artists, a key focus of the following section."

The *WJ* editors and their collaborative relationship with mangaka

This section examines the career progression and working conditions of *WJ* editors before exploring the intricate collaborative dynamics between these editors and freelance mangaka. This will shed light on how traditional business models intersect with the fluid, often unpredictable nature of creative industries.

The making of a *WJ* editor

Those lucky students who are hired by Shueisha and then assigned to *WJ*, become a part of a *WJ* editing team. The team consists of five or so groups, each comprising five to six editors. An individual editor manages between one to seven mangaka with a serialization. At the helm of the team is the editor-in-chief, whose decisions, influenced by industry lore (Havens 2014) play a pivotal role in determining magazine content (see also Boston and Duffy 2016, 215). Such power confers on *WJ* editors-in-chief a mystic aura, which subjects them to intense media attention and has often made them the subject of other popular culture.⁵

WJ's editor-in-chief profiles highlight a contrast between creative and uncreative aspects of production. Historically, all 11 *WJ* editors-in-chief have been Japanese males recruited directly by Shueisha. Unlike renowned Vogue editor-in-chief Anna Wintour, who accumulated experience across various publishers, Shueisha promotes its editors-in-chief internally. They adhere to a 'purebred' policy (Nishimura 1994, 321), in which *WJ*, while being subjected to Shueisha's job rotation policy, primarily recruits new students each spring who are not yet indoctrinated in other

divisions. Initially, *WJ* wasn't a top choice within Shueisha. Now, with its hit series and global impact, it has become a coveted position. Editors with successful series often stay longer, sometimes as long as 15 years, bypassing the usual rotation, highlighting their key role in *WJ*'s success (1101.com 2023).

Interestingly, there's a noticeable lack of diversity among *WJ*'s editors-in-chief in terms of gender, background, and even passion for manga. Most hail from a handful of universities, with as many as eight graduating from Waseda University. Their university degrees are commonly unrelated to publishing or any type of creative arts, with only two graduating with a literature degree. Masahiko Ibaraki, *WJ*'s eighth editor-in-chief, recalled that 'nobody in the *WJ* department was otaku', by which he meant that no one had a genuine love for manga and anime culture (Nakano 2019). Ibaraki and the four editors-in-chief that immediately preceded and followed him all had no interest in and had never read manga before they were assigned to *WJ*. According to Ibaraki, the *WJ* work culture was military-like, characterized by all-male masculine ethos and fierce competition among editors. *WJ*'s fifth editor-in-chief, Nobuhiko Horie, confessed that his assignment to *WJ* was an 'arranged marriage', not a love marriage (Oricon News 2018). It was only in the mid-1980s that the company began to make a gesture of asking employees their wishes concerning job assignments (See also Inaba 2016).

Even the most successful editor-in-chief at *WJ* cannot hold the position for long; they are typically rotated to a different job after an average of five years as editor-in-chief. As editor-in-chief, Nobuhiko Horie shepherded *WJ* to its all-time peak circulation of 6.53 million copies. Yet his tenure lasted only four years; after *WJ* he was moved to *Men's Non-no*, a men's fashion magazine, and then to *Bart*, a current affairs magazine (Maki 2016). Shueisha employees at all ranks are regularly rotated, not only between different publications but also to completely different departments. Despite *WJ*'s success, its editors' compensation remains on par with peers in less profitable sectors (Mannavi 2022).

The job security at Shueisha is extraordinary. For example, one former Shueisha editor, now in her mid-50s, mentioned that out of the 25 colleagues she joined the publisher with almost 30 years ago, only two have left. Similarly, editors-in-chief at Shueisha tend to stay until retirement, except for one who left to start an independent manga production company. A few other editors have made such transitions, such as Yohei Sadoshima from Kodansha, who founded a creator's agency, and more recently, Iyoku Akiyo, a former *WJ* editor, who formed a rights management firm leveraging his ties with Akira Toriyama, the creator of *Dragon Ball* (Weekly Bunshun Editors 2023). Nevertheless, the disproportionate media attention lavished on them underscores the rarity of such career shifts, as the vast majority of manga editors are reluctant to step out of major publishers, given the scale of their works and sufficient financial rewards.

Shueisha's lack of diversity, absence of specialization, and uniform pay structure are evident across all its departments and levels. Remarkably, the last eight Shueisha CEOs, all men, began and ended their careers within the company, starting in their early 20s and retiring in their 60s (Diamond Online 2019). While Shueisha does not publicly disclose employee salaries, it's reasonable to estimate that the CEO's salary doesn't exceed 50 million yen (approximately \$400,000). In contrast, consider Roger Lynch, an American who assumed the CEO role at Condé Nast in 2019, estimated to earn around \$10 million annually, 25 times more. Lynch's career path, common among Western media executives (Havens and Lotz 2017, 155–7), encompasses a tenure at Morgan Stanley following an MBA, and subsequent CEO positions at media-tech companies worldwide, including *Pandora* in the Bay area. Such career flexibility is rare among Japanese media companies like Shueisha, which consistently promote executives from within, highlighting its divergence from Western counterparts in neoliberal capitalism.

This section explores the inner workings of Shueisha's *WJ* editing team, elucidating how its adherence to traditional Japanese human resources management starkly contrasts with the neoliberal working conditions characteristic of Western creative industries. The remarkable job security, frequent job rotations, and stable working conditions at Shueisha offer insights into a distinct organizational culture that diverges from the volatile nature of many Western creative sectors, as documented in the literature. This foundational understanding sets the stage for an exploration of the dynamics between *WJ* editors and freelance mangaka, as we transition to the next section.

Editors' collaboration relationship with mangaka

How do editors as creative managers work with mangaka, and how is creativity pursued in a situation where creativity and precarity seem to be decoupled? I will use several published interviews with the current *Jump+* editor Mr. Lin Shihei, and other renowned editors in the past to describe editing processes and the key roles and responsibilities of editors at *WJ* in order to understand the collaborative production system of manga (Lin 2020; 1101.com 2023).

The editors at *WJ* are continuously on the lookout for promising new manga artists. They actively scout talent by holding awards for emerging mangaka, attending scouting events nationwide, participating in conventions like Comiket, and through outreach on social media. The editor who makes the initial contact, whether by receiving an in-person submission or fielding an unsolicited inquiry before rival editors, secures exclusive rights to the mangaka. The relationship between editors and mangaka lasts until an editor transfers out of *WJ*. This editor-mangaka bond persists until the editor leaves *WJ*. However, mangaka don't get to choose their editors, a dynamic sometimes referred to as the 'editor lottery,' reflecting its unpredictable nature and the significant impact it can have on their careers.

Currently, Lin stands out as perhaps the most renowned Shōnen Jump editor, having introduced the world to mega-hits such as '*Chainsaw Man*' by Tatsuki Fujimoto and '*Spy x Family*' over his 17 years of experience. In one interview, he revealed to the surprise of the interviewers that he currently oversees around 100 mangakas at various points in their careers, from novices to successful experienced mangaka. Though only seven of them have serializations in Shōnen Jump, he communicates with the rest on a regular basis. At Shōnen Jump, nothing is valued more than guiding new aspiring mangaka to serialization. Editors like Lin play a crucial role in guiding young mangakas, helping them evolve their initial ideas into fully realized manga over a considerable period taking as long as 10 years. This often starts with entries for various newcomer awards, leading to a one-shot manga feature in Shōnen Jump or one of its affiliate publications. If a mangaka consistently produces successful one-shots, the editor might then advocate at the serialization meetings for its serialization in Shōnen Jump – a significant landmark that can herald a substantial financial turnaround for the artist. Indeed, Lin volunteered to manage Fujimoto when he entered the award at the age of just 17. Fujimoto had been sending Lin new works every month until his eventual debut seven years later on *Jump+*, an online edition of Shōnen Jump.

As previously mentioned, most editors at *WJ* are college graduates without prior work experience or specialized education. They undergo on-the-job training with minimal mentoring from more experienced editors. These editors are often in competition with each other, not for higher pay but for peer recognition and job security within *WJ*. Skilled editors like Lin have emphasized that their learning process involves numerous trials and errors. For instance, in the year 2020, Lin brought more than 55 one-off mangas to publication while handling at least five ongoing serializations for 52 weeks. In each of these over 300 instances, he closely observed and adapted to immediate reader responses to refine his 'sensitivity', or industry lore, to discern what resonated with the audience. While widely seen as a hitmaker, Lin acknowledges possessing no secret formula for creating a hit manga: often, it is contingent on luck and the sheer volume of production, a luxury available to editors with higher job security.

In regular meetings with mangaka lasting anywhere from one to five hours, in a café, Denny's or mangaka's studio, editors offer guidance on plot development, character design, pacing, and other storytelling aspects.

The collaboration between *WJ* editors and mangakas represents a delicate interplay of contrasting yet complementary skills. A prime example is Kazuhiko Torishima, a former *WJ* editor-in-chief, renowned for his analytical and methodological approach. His meticulous study of a 1970s manga by Chiba Tetsuya, undertaken more than 50 times in the first months after his initial, albeit reluctant, assignment to *WJ*, exemplifies this commitment (Keio Times 2017). Torishima's in-depth analysis of

genre-specific elements, such as panel layouts and narrative angles, underpins his editorial success. This analytical rigor was demonstrated, for example, in his mentorship of Toriyama Akira, who would later create *Dragon Ball*, where he rejected over 500 pages of Toriyama's early works. This underscores the high editorial standards and diverse dynamics within the mangaka-editor relationship.

However, the dynamics between editors and mangaka vary depending on experience and personal preference. Editors also frequently suggest revisions to enhance the quality of manga. Some mangaka explicitly asks editors not to give any creative advice (Sato 2012), while others would appreciate detailed advice, as *WJ* editors are generally regarded as methodological and analytical.

While editors typically hold degrees from prestigious universities, mangaka often come from more modest backgrounds. For instance, among *WJ*'s top 10 best-selling mangaka, only one has a college degree. They debut as professional mangaka for *WJ* at an average age of 21, with no formal training in design, art, or any other creative discipline. Therefore, they tend to lack social skills, life experience, or cultural capital. These gaps require editors to sometimes act in a supportive manner but can also lead to patronizing and, at times, domineering behavior (e.g. Maki 2016, 205–14).⁶ Lin emphasized how editors serve as mentors, overseeing the eating, sleep, and exercise routines of mangaka. He even assisted a mangaka in searching for housing upon achieving success and signed off the contract as a contract guarantor, a not uncommon practice among editors. Editors also commonly kept mangaka informed about recent cultural trends, introducing them to books, other manga, films, and cultural texts that were currently popular. Lin sends lots of films and books to the mangaka to help them keep up with trends, nurture new ideas and sustain their creative sparks, which is crucial given their busy schedules; this exposure also helps bridge any cultural gaps stemming from the mangakas diverse, often self-taught backgrounds.

In *WJ*, 'Readers' Poll' are the ultimate indicators that determine the fate of a manga; they are the supreme decree to which editors and manga artists pay the utmost attention, as if it were a divine revelation (Myway Mook 2018; Nakano 2019, ; Nishimura 1994; Sunami 2014). The 'Readers' Poll' is a mail-in survey where readers vote for their favorite manga series and characters. This poll, elevated to a mythic level via repeated portrayals in popular culture, plays a pivotal role in deciding the fate of both established and emerging mangaka and their respective series. The final decision rests with the serialization meetings attended by the editor-in-chief and senior editors, but these decisions rarely contradict the poll's outcome. High-ranking manga series stand a strong chance of continued serialization, benefiting from enhanced visibility and marketing support. In contrast, low-ranking series risk cancellation to make room for new serialization. The phrase 'serialization canceled,' whether delivered via text, email, or in-person, is the most dreaded by mangaka (Maki 2016). Such a decision can drastically affect their livelihood, whereas editors remain insulated due to their lifetime employment status.

Uncreativity in action: editor-mangaka dynamics at *WJ*

The interaction between editors and mangaka at *WJ* illustrates the concept of 'uncreativity' in which structured guidance, repetitive tasks, and stability are as crucial as creative sparks in bringing manga visions to fruition in the production of manga.

This is particularly evident in the job security of editors as compared to the precarious freelance nature of mangaka. Lin sarcastically introduced an industry saying: a seasoned *WJ* editor stands on the corpses of tens or hundreds of mangaka (1101.com 2023). The relationship is indeed asymmetrical and marked by a rigid hierarchy, which causes friction and tensions, as documented in many accounts by mangaka (Aoki 2019) and editors (e.g. Kimura 2015; Sato 2012). At the same time, he and other editors conscientiously strive to mitigate the unpredictable career trajectory of mangaka, and help them to align their creative outputs with cultural trends and market preferences. With the freedom and long-term thinking afforded by job security, editors can advocate for the development of distinctive and long-lasting styles, innovative storytelling, and nurturing mangaka, for instance,

like Lin's relationship with Fujimoto, to push the boundaries of the genre. This runs counter to the increasingly common neoliberal narrative that associates freelancing with creative freedom, suggesting instead that the assurance of stability can enhance creativity by allowing for long-term planning and ambitious projects without the immediate pressure of financial success.

In manga production, the collaboration between mangakas and *WJ* editors is marked by a unique interplay of creativity and methodology. Mangakas provide spontaneous creativity, while editors often apply structured, analytical insights. This partnership could transcend professional interactions, deeply influencing the mangaka's work. The 'Readers' Poll' exemplifies this dynamic, aligning creative directions with audience preferences and balancing artistic vision with market feedback.

Through Bilton's 'uncreativity' lens (2015), this relationship showcases a fusion of editorial precision and mangaka creativity, crucial for both the artistic integrity and commercial success of manga. The 'Readers' Poll' emerges as a key indicator, validating the effectiveness of this collaborative process.

Conclusion: embracing the paradox of uncreative workers

In concluding our exploration into Shueisha's world and the career trajectories of its editors, we grapple with a striking paradox. It defies the prevalent Western notions of creative labor by revealing how elite university graduates, endowed with broad cultural capital but often lacking training or relevant work experience, join the manga industry through Shueisha. Their motivations are complex, often driven by financial rewards, job stability, and societal status rather than a single-minded passion for manga. This stands in contrast to the romanticized ideal of the impassioned creative workers (Bhansing, Hitters, and Wijngaarden 2018), yet it is within this very framework that some individuals, such as Shimatori and Lin, have risen to become era-defining editors who have significantly impacted manga and Japanese popular culture more broadly.

This phenomenon calls into question the conventional wisdom that creative managers must be fervently passionate and intrinsically motivated to succeed. Shueisha's model demonstrates that creative productivity and influential editorial work can also flourish within a structure prioritizing job security, egalitarian principles, and a preference for generalist skills. This corporate context in Shueisha and in some parts of Japanese creative industries more generally, fostering creativity in a secure and organized environment, regardless of their original motivation, contrasts with the Western discourse, which often correlates creativity with an environment that encourages autonomy, hyper-mobility, and self-enterprise.

The traditional trade-off at Shueisha, where employees sarcastically refer to themselves as 'salary-men,' involves exchanging career autonomy for security by accepting frequent and random assignments to different jobs. This might appear to be a surrender of creativity, where the freedom to pursue individual creative interests or develop specialized skills is often secondary to the needs of the company. Yet, such an interpretation may overlook an alternative manifestation of creativity. Shueisha editors, including figures such as Lin and Shimatori, don't use the term 'creativity,' but they often express a drive to engage with 'interesting work.' For Lin, this even involved tasks like picking up the manga draft on the last train from Tokyo to a mangaka's studio in the suburbs (1101.com 2023). This distinction suggests that creativity is not limited to artistic pursuits but can also encompass a wide spectrum of work activities. From this perspective, the seeming surrender of control can be seen as a pathway to diversified engagement, fostering a dynamic interplay of skills and roles. This aligns with a broader Japanese cultural appreciation, and sometimes a societal expectation, to find satisfaction in work that is not narrowly defined by innovation but also includes finding meaning and joy in varied responsibilities. Therefore, what might be misconstrued as an abandonment of creativity may, in reality, be an alternative interpretation of creativity—one that embraces the many ways individuals can find their work interesting and fulfilling.

The Shueisha narrative ultimately prompts a reassessment of the creative labor paradigm, suggesting that a stable and structured environment can, in some circumstances, be conducive to innovation. The company's ethos fosters a culture where creativity is a collective pursuit,

benefiting from long-term stability and strategic corporate direction. At first glance, it appears to be the conditions that enable ‘good work’ in cultural industries that normative and social justice approach scholars have been exploring (Banks 2017; Hesmondhalgh and Baker 2011). However, the Shueisha model is not without its critiques, as it does not fully address issues such as the lack of autonomy deficits and rigid hierarchical structures, factors that have propelled creative workers globally towards self-employment and freelancing in the first place (Ross 2009, 5–6).

Nevertheless, the story of Shueisha’s *WJ* and its editors, an untold tale of achieving global influence without aligning itself with the Western neoliberal model, beckons us to expand and complicate our understanding of creative labor. Echoing Fung’s (2017, 202) challenge to the very notion of ‘creativity,’ it underscores the impact of socio-political contexts on creative industries and the laborers within them, resulting in diverse conceptions of creativity. This recognition is crucial as the creative industries’ global landscape is evolving toward divergence as much as convergence (Oyama and Lolli 2016), necessitating a more nuanced and contextualized understanding of the diverse terrains of creative work that enables us to imagine alternative and improved futures for creative works and industries.

Notes

1. In this article, ‘WS’ signifies ‘Weekly Shōnen Jump,’ the traditional print publication. ‘Jump+’ refers to ‘Shonen Jump Plus,’ a digital platform that carries digital editions of Weekly Shōnen Jump as well as original titles and titles from other Shueisha manga magazines. When I use ‘Shōnen Jump’ without a prefix, it encompasses both the print and online formats.
2. I have opted for the term ‘creative managers’ rather than similar concepts, such as ‘cultural intermediaries.’ For a more comprehensive discussion on its conceptual distinctions, see Hesmondhalgh (2006).
3. For example, the nephew of former Prime Minister Shinzo Abe works at Fuji Television, and Abe’s wife worked at Dentsu, the largest advertising agency in Japan (Oyama and Dario 2016).
4. The lack of media programs at elite universities and creative industries’ indifference to students’ academic specialization articulate a different kind of politics from the central role of the ‘entrepreneurial’ arts and humanities university in the UK, as criticized by McRobbie (2016).
5. Popular culture works featuring editors-in-chief of *WS* include books and biographies (Mook 2018; Nishimura 1994; Sunami 2014), film and television documentaries (NHK 2018; One 2015; Ooki 2018), and numerous appearances in manga series, including *Bakuman* (Ooba and Obata 2009) and *Reedom* (Tsugihara 2009).
6. As for the contractual arrangements of manga artists, artists generally have only a verbal agreement with Shueisha up until the time a manga is serialized in *WS*; the editors can terminate this agreement at any time, based primarily on how well the manga performs in reader surveys. Artists are only offered a written contract when *tankōbon* (stand-alone volumes of a manga series) are published (e.g. Maki 2016; Sato 2012).

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